IMPERIALISM: AN OVERVIEW

The subjugation of large parts of the world constitutes an important episode in the history of international relations. Realpolitik involves the urge of states to acquire jurisdiction and exercise domination over the territories and peoples of other states. The ultimate aim is expansion and enhancement of national prestige and asserting their power. This has led to the acquisition of colonies, setting up of economic dependencies and satellites. When such practices become a part and parcel of a foreign policy objective of a state, it is often said that the state is engaging in imperialism.

Though imperialism and colonialism have long been employed as instruments of national policy, there is no agreed definition about imperialism. Some scholars try to define imperialism as "a policy which aims at creating, organizing, and maintaining an empire; that is, a state of vast size composed of various more or less distinct national units and subject to a single centralized will". According to Charles A. Beard* "Imperialism is … employment of the engines of government and diplomacy to acquire territories, protectorates, and/or spheres of influences occupied usually by other races or peoples, and to promote industrial, trade, and investment opportunities". Parker T. Moon‡ defines imperialism as "domination of non-European native races by totally dissimilar European nations".

Joseph Schumpeter‡, a distinguished Austrian economist, regarded imperialism as an "atavistic force, ancient in inception, decadent and self-conscious in an age of rationalism, yet still powerful enough to lord it over its rival, the upstart capitalism".

Charles Hodges§ offered a much more convincing definition of imperialism as "a projection externally, directly or indirectly, of alien political, economic, or cultural power of one nation into the internal life of another people. … it involves the imposition of control—open or covert, direct or indirect —of one people by another" and it "is to affect the destinies of the backward people in the interest of more advanced from the stand point of world power".[1]

The terms 'colonialism' and 'imperialism' are used interchangeably although they mean two different things. Usually, 'colony' is a people